

Why we suck

Four years of our drafts and waiver claims, pulled apart. Two things came out.

1. Almost none of it is bad drafting

Across the league, **72% of the picks that blew up in rounds 1–4 were injuries**, not misjudgements. A healthy early pick averages 14 points a game. Here are your six:

Year	Rd	Player	Games	Pts/gm	vs slot	
2023	R1	Nick Chubb	2	10.6	-157	injured
2022	R4	Elijah Mitchell	4	6.2	-94	injured
2025	R3	Mike Evans	3	9.0	-87	injured
2023	R4	Cam Akers	7	5.9	-78	injured
2024	R4	Rashee Rice	4	13.5	-71	injured
2022	R3	Kyle Pitts	10	6.2	-51	played badly

Rashee Rice was scoring 13.5 a game and played four of them. Chubb was at 10.6 and played two. **You have one genuine miss in four years** — Kyle Pitts, who played ten games and was bad. Everything else was a knee.

Out of 36 such busts league-wide, 26 were injuries: **72%**, with a 95% interval of [56%, 84%].

2. But you draft young, and young is where things break

Splitting every early-round running back, receiver and tight end in the league by age at the time he was drafted:

Age when drafted	Picks	Bust rate	95% interval	Avg value
Under 25	77	23%	[15%, 34%]	−5.1
25 to 28	89	8%	[4%, 15%]	+2.3
29 and over	37	16%	[7%, 31%]	+1.4

The gap between the first two rows is **16 percentage points**, interval [5, 26]; as a ratio, under-25 picks bust **3.0 times** as often, interval [1.3, 6.7]. A two-proportion test gives $z = 2.79$, $p = 0.005$. That test assumes a normal approximation, so I also shuffled the age labels 200,000 times and counted how often a gap this large appeared by chance: 1,690 times, $p = 0.008$. Same answer without the assumption.

You take 67% of your early skill picks under 25, interval [42%, 85%]. The league takes 38%, interval [32%, 45%]. I take 21%. Mitchell, Akers, Rice and Pitts were all 24 or younger. You are not drafting badly; you are drafting young, and young is where the variance lives. Bijan and Chase are why you keep doing it.

3. Three things that did *not* hold up

- **Age as a straight line.** The correlation between age and games played is -0.013 , interval $[-0.15, +0.13]$. Dead zero. The effect is not “older is worse” — the 29-and-over group is no worse than average. Only the young end is unusual.
- **Avoiding injury-prone players.** Players drafted after a season in which they missed five or more weeks

busted 10% of the time. Players who had been healthy busted 19%. The obvious heuristic is backwards here, though on only 20 picks.

- **The idea that some of us are simply better.** Year-to-year correlation in season wins across the league is -0.10 . Top-four finishes repeat 25% of the time; chance alone gives 29%. Nobody in this league persists.

4. And my problem is the opposite

I put in **11 waiver claims a season**. The league median is 35. You are at 35 yourself, which is the one thing you do better than almost anyone here. When Nabers went down in week 4 last year I lost a first-round receiver and simply never replaced him.

How the numbers were built, and how far to trust them

Every pick is scored the same way. A player's fantasy points in weeks 1–14 are compared against *replacement level* – what the best freely available player at his position scored that season, computed by filling all fourteen starting lineups and taking the next man. That difference is then compared against what picks at that draft slot typically return, averaged over every pick within twelve slots of it. A “bust” is a pick landing 50 or more points below that, which is roughly three and a half points a week from a starting spot across a season.

Two reasons to take it seriously: it is not a sample. Every pick and every claim either of us has made on Sleeper is in here, so there is no sampling error in the descriptive figures – 67% of your early picks really were under 25. And the age result survived a permutation test, which makes no distributional assumption at all.

Two reasons for caution, which matter more. **I chose the age bands after looking at the data**, and I ran perhaps twenty comparisons over the course of this: positions, draft slots, schedule effects, injury history, waiver behaviour, lineup efficiency. Bonferroni against twenty tests turns $p = 0.005$ into $p = 0.10$. And 36 busts is not many. **Treat the age finding as the best lead we have, not as established** – the honest test is whether it holds in 2026, on a season nobody has looked at yet.

Sleeper data, 2022–2025, 798 draft picks and 1,089 waiver auctions. A “bust” is a pick returning 50+ points less than that draft slot normally does, measured against the position's replacement level.